

SuperStart Mentorship Programme

Overview of the SuperStart Mentorship Programme

SuperStart is FirstRand's early-career mentorship programme, designed to intentionally support and shape the journeys of new and early-in-role employees across the Group. The programme aims to improve the first-job experience by ensuring employees begin their careers with clarity, confidence, and a meaningful connection to both their work and the organisation. Rather than leaving early development to chance or informal support, SuperStart embeds mentorship from the outset, recognising that how people start their careers has a lasting impact on their growth, engagement, and long-term success.

At its core, SuperStart offers a guided mentorship journey that goes beyond technical performance and day-to-day delivery. The programme takes a holistic approach to early-career development, acknowledging that confidence, self-awareness, emotional intelligence, and a sense of belonging are foundational to sustainable professional growth. Through consistent guidance and reflection, participants build personal and professional confidence, gain greater self-insight, and learn how their behaviour and impact are experienced within the workplace.

SuperStart also supports early-career employees in navigating the realities of the professional environment—helping demystify organisational norms, expectations, and the informal dynamics that are rarely taught but critical for success. By creating structured opportunities for connection and support, the programme reduces the isolation and uncertainty often experienced by first-jobbers. In doing so, SuperStart positions mentorship not as an optional add-on, but as a foundational part of the early-career experience, reinforcing FirstRand's commitment to intentional development, inclusion, and long-term talent growth.

Who SuperStart Is and What It Aims to Achieve

Purpose of SuperStart

SuperStart exists to ensure that every person entering FirstRand—particularly those in their first professional role—begins their career journey feeling supported, grounded, and prepared for the workplace. The programme is

intentionally designed to remove early uncertainty and to create a strong foundation for long-term growth from the very start of an employee's career.

The programme provides consistent support for new and early-in-role employees across the organisation, spanning teams and functions so that access to guidance is not limited by organisational boundaries. By offering a shared mentorship experience, SuperStart reduces reliance on informal, manager-dependent support and helps create a more equitable early-career experience. Participants receive a consistent quality of guidance, regardless of where they sit in the organisation, enabling smoother professional transitions into role expectations, workplace norms, and ways of working.

Through its structured mentorship approach, SuperStart focuses not only on helping employees succeed in their current roles, but on preparing them for sustainable career success. The programme directly addresses the uncertainty and anxiety commonly experienced by first-jobbers by providing clarity, reassurance, and trusted guidance. As a result, participants build confidence in navigating both role demands and organisational culture, strengthening long-term career readiness, resilience, and self-assurance beyond short-term performance outcomes.

Origin of the SuperStart Programme

The SuperStart programme originated from a simple but important question: *“What if every early career hire had one consistent, structured source of guidance focused on their growth, not just their performance?”* This question highlighted a gap in the early career experience and became the foundation for rethinking how new talent is supported at FirstRand.

Historically, early career experiences across FirstRand varied significantly. Some new joiners benefited from strong mentorship and consistent support, while others struggled—not because of a lack of ability, but because the quality of support depended heavily on individual managers or team cultures. This inconsistency created uneven outcomes and unnecessary uncertainty for employees at the start of their careers.

In response to this gap, the 2025 Graduate Mentorship Portfolio was tasked with reimagining early career support across the organisation. This work led to the creation of SuperStart as a deliberately designed, scalable mentorship offering.

- **Structured development journey:** SuperStart was designed as a clear, end to end journey that combines virtual and in person touchpoints, ensuring continuity, progression, and sustained engagement.
- **Growth focused mentorship model:** The programme places emphasis on self-awareness, confidence, emotional intelligence, and career readiness, rather than focusing only on technical performance.
- **Peer and near peer mentoring approach:** Mentors are positioned close enough in experience to relate authentically and practically to mentees, enabling realistic guidance and stronger connection.
- **Scalable group wide design:** The programme was built to support early career talent consistently across the broader FirstRand Group, without losing relevance or impact.

SuperStart was intentionally designed to create consistency, reduce uncertainty, and help new joiners find their footing faster. By shifting early career support from informal and uneven to structured and intentional, the programme lays a stronger foundation for confidence, growth, and long-term success.

Founding Team and Accountability

Initial Team

The mentorship initiative was founded and led by members of the 2025 Graduate Programme: Nathan Ngqwebo, Noluthando Buthelezi, Malamba Lavhengwa, and Andiswa Mashimbye, operating under the Graduate Executive Committee's Mentorship Portfolio. The programme was developed with guidance and support from the following contributors: Ntsiki Morrison, Mosa Seloane, and Zaheer Ismail, whose experience and insight helped shape its design and direction. Established to support First Job entrants, the initiative focuses on providing clarity, confidence, and a sense of belonging as First-Jobbers begin their careers. Over the past year, the founding team designed, implemented, and sustained the programme through their graduate tenure and into their second year, demonstrating continuity of ownership, strong commitment, and a lasting contribution to early-career development and organisational culture.

Why SuperStart was created

SuperStart was created in response to a clear gap identified in the early career experience within the First Job Programme at FirstRand. While talent entered the organisation with strong potential, their early experiences were often shaped by inconsistent levels of support and guidance.

Several key challenges were identified across the early career journey.

- **Limited structured support:** Many first jobbers entered the organisation without access to a consistent or formal support structure to help them transition into the workplace.
- **Manager dependent mentorship:** Mentorship experiences varied widely and depended heavily on individual managers or team environments rather than on a shared organisational approach.
- **Inconsistent onboarding and development:** Early onboarding and development experiences differed across business areas, resulting in unequal exposure, guidance, and growth opportunities.

As a result of these challenges, some early career employees began their time at FirstRand feeling unsupported, unseen, and uncertain about their roles, expectations, and long-term growth paths. This uncertainty was not linked to capability, but rather to the absence of intentional early career guidance.

SuperStart was created to directly address these challenges by providing a consistent, intentional mentorship framework. The programme ensures that no young professional enters FirstRand without guidance, connection, and clarity, establishing a stronger and more equitable foundation for confidence, belonging, and long-term career success.

Design Principles

These principles guided every decision made in designing SuperStart and shaped how the programme was built to be fair, scalable, and practical. They establish a clear foundation for how support is delivered, how participants engage, and how the programme sustains impact over time.

- **Consistency over ad-hoc support:** The programme prioritises a structured and repeatable experience so that every participant receives the same level of support. This approach reduces randomness and dependency on individual managers, creating a reliable and equitable baseline for development.
- **Equal access to guidance:** SuperStart is designed to ensure that all early-career hires have the same opportunity to learn and grow. Access to guidance is not influenced by team, role, or confidence level, helping to level the playing field across the organisation.
- **Shared accountability:** Successful outcomes are treated as a joint responsibility. Both mentors and mentees are accountable for progress, engagement, and results, reinforcing balanced ownership rather than placing the burden on one side of the relationship.

- **Human-centred, operationally light:** The design focuses on real human development and meaningful relationships, while deliberately remaining easy to run. Administrative effort is kept minimal so that energy is spent on people, not process.
- **Scalable without losing impact:** SuperStart is built to grow across cohorts and departments without becoming diluted or impersonal. As participation increases, the programme maintains its quality, relevance, and personal value.

What SuperStart Is Today

A Clear Definition of the Programme

This chapter defines SuperStart in clear, practical terms to ensure a shared understanding of its purpose and structure. By clearly articulating what the programme is and how it works, it removes ambiguity, sets consistent expectations, and creates alignment for participants, mentors, and the organisation.

SuperStart is a structured, time-bound mentorship programme designed to provide early-career hires with consistent guidance through a defined development journey. The programme is focused on progression, helping participants build confidence, capability, and clarity as they move from entry into effective contribution.

- **Structured mentorship cycles:** The programme operates with a clear start, middle, and end, avoiding open-ended or informal arrangements. This structure creates momentum, supports commitment, and ensures that development feels purposeful and time-bound.
- **Joint mentor–mentee onboarding:** Both mentors and mentees begin the programme aligned on its purpose, expectations, and boundaries. This shared onboarding establishes clarity from the outset and supports stronger, more effective mentoring relationships.
- **Guided development themes:** Each phase of the programme is centred on specific growth areas, such as confidence building, skill development, and career navigation. This ensures development is intentional, progressive, and relevant to early-career needs.
- **Integrated with talent systems:** SuperStart is designed to work alongside existing onboarding, performance, and development processes. Rather than operating in isolation, it strengthens and complements current talent systems to create a cohesive employee experience.

End-to-End Mentorship Journey

How the Programme Works in Practice

This chapter explains how SuperStart operates end-to-end, translating the programme's principles into a clear, practical flow. The structure is intentionally visible and well-governed, ensuring that the experience is consistent, accountable, and manageable at scale rather than reliant on informal or ad-hoc arrangements.

- **Early mentor sourcing:** Mentors are identified and confirmed ahead of mentee onboarding. This ensures readiness, avoids last-minute matching, and signals that mentorship is a deliberate and valued commitment rather than an afterthought.
- **Formal mentor registration:** Mentors formally register their participation, establishing role clarity, expectations, and commitment from the outset. This step supports quality, consistency, and accountability across the programme.
- **Mentor–mentee matching:** Pairings are based on development needs, relevant experience, and mutual availability. This intentional matching increases the likelihood of productive, meaningful mentoring relationships.
- **Joint training and expectation setting:** Mentors and mentees are onboarded together to build a shared understanding of goals, cadence, boundaries, and responsibilities. This alignment reduces mismatch and sets a solid foundation for the relationship.
- **Structured five-month mentorship cycle:** The programme runs over a defined five-month period, supported by regular check-ins, prompts, and development themes. This structure maintains momentum while allowing space for reflection and growth.
- **Midpoint and final feedback:** Formal reflection points enable course correction, shared learning, and assessment of progress. These milestones support both individual development and continuous improvement of the programme.
- **Close-out, reporting, and insights:** Outcomes and insights are documented at the end of the cycle to inform future cohorts, strengthen governance, and continuously refine the programme design.

Intent

The programme flow is designed to demonstrate robustness, governance, and risk awareness while creating visibility and accountability across the full mentorship journey. By making each stage explicit, SuperStart ensures that progress is trackable, responsibilities are clear, and learning is captured for long-term impact.

Experience & Value Created

Who Benefits – and How

This section outlines the value of SuperStart across all participants, making explicit how the programme creates impact at the individual and organisational levels. By clearly articulating

benefits, it reinforces why the programme is meaningful, mutually valuable, and strategically important.

From the mentee perspective, SuperStart is designed to create a supportive and confidence building early career experience.

- **Psychological safety:** Mentees gain access to a trusted space where they can ask questions, make mistakes, and learn without fear of judgement or negative consequences.
- **Faster confidence building:** Regular guidance and reassurance reduce uncertainty and help accelerate self-belief and professional confidence.
- **Clearer expectations and goals:** Mentees develop a stronger understanding of role requirements, performance expectations, and growth pathways within the organisation.
- **Practical workplace skills:** Through real world insights and advice, mentees build practical skills that are often not formally taught but are critical for success at work.

For mentors, the programme offers meaningful development beyond technical contribution.

- **Leadership development:** Mentors strengthen coaching, influencing, and people development capabilities through firsthand practice.
- **Coaching and feedback exposure:** The structured nature of the programme creates intentional opportunities to practise giving thoughtful, constructive feedback.
- **Sense of purpose and contribution:** Mentors experience direct impact by supporting and shaping the next generation of talent, reinforcing engagement and fulfilment.

At an organisational level, SuperStart delivers measurable cultural and talent benefits.

- **Smoother early career onboarding:** Early support enables faster ramp up for new hires and reduces the risk of early attrition.
- **Healthier learning culture:** The programme reinforces development, support, and shared responsibility as organisational norms rather than exceptions.
- **Stronger early talent signal:** By investing in people from day one, the organisation demonstrates a tangible commitment to growth, capability building, and long-term talent sustainability.

Evidence & Signals We Observe

Ongoing Mentor Demand

We've received growing interest in peer mentorship across early-career mentees. There is anecdotal evidence of first-year employees, outside of the formal First Job Programme, actively expressing interest in peer mentorship relationships. This indicates that the need

SuperStart addresses extends beyond the immediate programme cohort and reflects a broader demand during early corporate transitions.

In addition, several current SuperStart mentors have proactively referred peers who are interested in joining the programme as mentors. This organic advocacy signals that mentors themselves find value in the experience and see the programme as credible and worthwhile.

Growing Internal Interest

Interest from existing First Job management and support structures has been highly encouraging. Engagement conversations have demonstrated strong alignment between the SuperStart objectives, and the needs observed by programme managers on the ground.

Initial discussions, including engagement with Annemarie Vermeulen, have highlighted executive and operational curiosity around how structured peer mentorship can complement line-manager support, improve learner confidence, and strengthen transition readiness. These signals suggest increasing appetite for scaling or formalising mentorship as part of the broader early-talent ecosystem.

Team Growth & Continuity

Team Growth

With the arrival of the 2026 graduate cohort, a new Mentorship Portfolio was appointed, comprising Mikael Zandamela, Morris Nkomo, Nadia Abdul Khaliq, and Zubair Hussain. A structured handover with the outgoing team ensured continuity through shared context, lessons learnt, and clarity on programme objectives. Both cohorts collaborated closely to expand mentor mentee matching, refine processes, and strengthen strategic direction, resulting in a more mature, structured, and effective programme.

Intentional Onboarding

The programme's growth and reach are enabled by intentional mentor and mentee onboarding through the FirstRand Workday platform. Mentors register, complete required training, and are onboarded as transitional mentors, while mentees connect with their allocated mentors via the same platform. Hosting the full lifecycle on Workday enhances accessibility, visibility, and engagement, allowing the programme to extend beyond first-job entrants to a broader junior employee base.

Active Knowledge Transfer & Shared Ownership

The programme promotes active knowledge transfer and shared ownership by embedding its framework, processes, and principles within Workday. This institutionalises learning, creates a scalable and repeatable mentoring model, and ensures the programme is not owned by a single cohort. As a result, the framework can be leveraged to support similar

development initiatives across different fields, enabling broader organisational learning and sustainable capability building. SuperStart is being built to outlive its founders.

Why SuperStart Is Ready for Executive Support

Clear Operating Model

SuperStart operates within a well-defined and repeatable framework that spans programme initiation, mentor sourcing, mentor matching, and data tracking. Each phase of the mentorship journey is designed with clear timelines, standardised check-ins, and measurable outputs, ensuring consistency across cohorts while allowing room for continuous improvement.

Defined Ownership

The portfolio is supported by a well-defined role structure with accountable owners for stakeholder management, programme communication, data and insights, and Relationship Management. This clarity of ownership enables strong governance, effective decision-making, and seamless collaboration with key stakeholders such as First Job, Young Talent, and related business units.

Low Cost, High Human Return

SuperStart delivers meaningful impact with minimal financial overhead by leveraging internal talent, peer mentorship, and existing Workday tools. The value generated in improved First Job learner confidence, faster work readiness, and leadership capability development for mentors represents a high return on human capital investment.

Alignment with Talent Priorities

The programme is directly aligned to the organisation's early-career and talent pipeline priorities, supporting smoother transitions into the workplace, stronger retention, and the development of future leaders. SuperStart complements existing line management and team-based support structures, reinforcing a holistic talent development ecosystem.

Proven Ability to Run End-to-End Cycles

SuperStart has demonstrated the capability to design, launch, deliver, evaluate, and iterate full mentorship cycles end to end. From onboarding and matching through to feedback analysis and insight reporting, the programme has consistently met delivery milestones and incorporated learnings to improve subsequent cycles.

The Ask

SuperStart is requesting focused executive support to enable formal recognition, sustainable growth, and measurable impact within the Bank's early-career talent ecosystem.

1. Executive Endorsement

We are requesting formal endorsement from Exco to position SuperStart as the Bank's official peer-mentorship advocate for First Job learners.

With executive endorsement:

- SuperStart can be communicated and recognised as an approved mentorship capability.
- The programme can signal readiness to scale beyond the First Job programme.
- SuperStart can be positioned as template model for a more formalised buddy-mentorship initiative within the FNB Graduate Programme.

This endorsement will remove uncertainty around legitimacy, longevity, and strategic relevance.

2. Continued Integration into Talent Ecosystems

We are seeking continued and deepened integration of SuperStart into existing talent structures, particularly First Job, and all Graduate Programmes within the Group.

Specifically:

- Formalise SuperStart's role within the First Job support model. Specifically, through integration into the work-readiness portion of the programme.
- Expand SuperStart's contribution by giving back to the FNB Graduate Programme through a structured buddy-mentorship approach.

This integration will enable seamless early-career transitions while avoiding duplication of effort.

3. Visibility and Executive Sponsorship

We are requesting increased visibility and active sponsorship to strengthen SuperStart's reach and credibility.

This includes:

- Executive acknowledgement and advocacy where appropriate.
- Visibility in talent related communications and forums.
- Support in positioning SuperStart as a leadership and development opportunity for early-career employees.

Improved visibility is essential to attract and retain high-quality mentors and to scale participation sustainably.

4. Permission and Support to Scale Mentor Sourcing

We are requesting permission and support to broaden the mentor pool by accessing a larger cohort of early-career employees who are sufficiently settled in their roles.

Specifically:

- Approval to approach individuals beyond the current Graduate Programme cohort under the banner of SuperStart.
- Support in positioning mentorship as a recognised developmental opportunity
- Alignment with managers to encourage their participation.

This will ensure mentorship demand can be met without over-reliance on a small, fixed mentor population.

Closing Message

SuperStart is more than a programme. It is a commitment to ensuring no one starts their career feeling unsupported, uncertain, or alone.